

2.6 What Format Should I Use?

To the extreme audiophile, even a CD doesn't sound as good as analogue. But since we're talking digital audio here, what audio format is best suited for ripping your CDs into? For some people, it makes no difference—128 kbps MP3s sound as good as anything else, especially when they're listened to on lo-fi equipment with lo-fi earphones. But the more discerning amongst us are concerned about formats, while still wanting to save space on their hard disks or portable audio players.

There's a large variation in how people perceive music, and the best way to figure out what format you want to use is to experiment by yourself, encoding at different bitrates. But still, here's one reviewer's take we found on crutchfieldadvisor.com:

"The question before the aspiring digital music enthusiast is, which format sounds the best? The market abounds with portable MP3 players, almost all of which are compatible with MP3. Most can also play WMA; some can handle AAC files. Most players decode and play back files directly from their original file format, but some portables come with software that transcodes files into a separate format, which is then read by the player. But in either case, the quality of the sound that reaches your ears depends on, among other things, the quality of the codec you used to save the music to your hard drive in the first place. So I decided to set up a listening test to find out which of those codecs would come out on top in terms of sound quality.

"The low-bitrate MP3 was everyone's least favourite. One listener noted a lack of overall detail, as well as 'metallic artefacts' replacing the high frequencies.

"Secondly, I was surprised to find that the uncompressed file did not receive the highest rating—that honour went to the high-bitrate AAC file. Perhaps I should have expected this since, in an earlier attempt at a listening test that pitted 96 kbps, 128 kbps,